

ON THE RIGHT TRACK

- **Metro rail has improved urban connectivity across tier-1 and -2 cities, benefiting millions of commuters**
- **Real estate values have surged along metro lines, fostering thriving business and residential hubs**
- **Boosted employment in construction, operations, retail, real estate and other allied sectors**
- **Reduced urban pollution and traffic congestion, supporting eco-friendly city planning**
- **Gave a fillip to indigenous production of train components while boosting investments by global players like Alstom and Siemens**
- **Inspired advanced designs and systems like Regional Rapid Transit Systems**



"We have an ambition, that every government department and all employees become as efficient as the Delhi Metro.... Delhi Metro is a role model"

***— SHEILA DIKSHIT,** former Delhi chief minister, on the Delhi Metro's foundation day in 2012*

Legend has it that when the first underground metro train began running between Bhowanipore and Esplanade in Calcutta in 1984, there were more gawking onlookers than riders for it. Perhaps because it had taken such a long time coming, for the foundation stone for the Calcutta Metro had been laid some 12 years earlier, in 1972, by then prime minister Indira Gandhi. The project had found the going painstakingly slow, and few would have envisioned the impact it would have on urban transport in India. But that modest beginning planted the seeds of a metro rail revolution that would transform India over the next four decades.

Around the same time, in 1984, the Urban Arts Commission in Delhi proposed a multi-modal transport system, including underground mass rapid transit corridors to complement the national capital's transport networks. But that vision only began to materialise in the late 1990s. In 2002, the Delhi Metro began operations, heralding a new era of urban mobility in India. It also made E. Sreedharan the 'Metro Man' of India. His earlier success with the 760-km Konkan Railway line had led to his appointment as MD of the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation. Starting in 1998, under Sreedharan the project introduced cutting-edge technologies such as tunnel boring machines and world-class metro coaches. Remarkably, the first elevated section—connecting Shahdara to Tis Hazari—was completed in just four years.

The Delhi Metro's success proved to be a turning point, inspiring other cities to follow suit. From Bengaluru to Mumbai, metro systems began to spring up across India. Even Tier-2 cities like Jaipur and Agra joined the movement, demonstrating that urban mobility was no longer confined to major metropolitan hubs. Today, India boasts the third largest metro network in the world, 945 km operational across 21 cities with an additional 919 km coming up in 26 cities. The metro's impact has been far-reaching, offering millions of commuters a safe and fast alternative to the congested roads. It has also spurred economic growth, with real estate prices soaring along metro routes with developers leveraging the enhanced connectivity. Cities like Kochi and Pune have integrated metro networks into broader urban planning, reshaping neighbourhoods. But there has been criticism too, mostly focused on whether ridership levels validate such huge capital-intensive investments, especially in Tier-2 cities.

But that is offset by the metro becoming a catalyst for sustainable development. Energy-efficient trains and solar-powered infrastructure align with India's climate goals, while local production of trains and components by companies like BEML Ltd and Titagarh Rail Systems has reduced reliance on imports. While the Kolkata Metro laid the foundation, proving that India could effectively operate a metro system, Delhi redefined the benchmarks for scale, speed and technological advancement. ■



FROM THE ARCHIVES
Dec. 15, 1984

West Bengal **Metro Mania**

To most Calcuttans, the train looks like a science fiction fantasy. The Metro certainly cuts down on travel time, and though the percentage of regular users is small, it is increasing and will become significant once the entire southern stretch becomes operational.

–Indranil Banerjie